ChurchManager User Guide

Version 0.3.0-beta.5

For congregations using ChurchManager

ChurchManager brings worship planning, people and family records, attendance, reports, communications, and fund accounting into one congregation-owned application. This guide explains the ordinary tasks a user performs. Technical installation and development procedures are maintained separately.

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1. Getting started

Installing ChurchManager

MariaDB Server for Windows is required and must be installed separately before ChurchManager. Include MariaDB's command-line client and backup tools when installing it. ChurchManager identifies this requirement explicitly if either `mariadb.exe` or `mariadb-dump.exe` cannot be found. Download MariaDB Server from the official MariaDB Foundation download page.

The ChurchManager Setup wizard checks the computer first, then collects the local database connection, congregation name, first Master Administrator, and optional catalog choices. Its review page never displays a password. The temporary Master Administrator password must be changed at first login.

During development the wizard opens in **preview mode**, which validates the complete plan without creating a database or changing saved credentials.

Sign in

Start ChurchManager from its Windows shortcut. Enter the user name and password provided by the congregation administrator. A temporary password must be changed when requested. Each person should use an individual account; accounts must not be shared.

ChurchManager passwords initially require at least eight characters. An authorized user administrator can set a congregation-wide minimum between 8 and 128 characters in User Administration. When creating a user, an administrator may select **Generate** to create a secure temporary password at the active minimum length. ChurchManager displays that generated value only in the active dialog so it can be copied and communicated separately; welcome email never includes the temporary password.

The Reset Password dialog offers the same **Generate** option and uses the active congregation minimum. The generated reset password must likewise be communicated separately to the user.

Inactive accounts remain listed in User Administration but use the Windows disabled-item colors to distinguish them from active accounts. The Active column also displays **No**, so the status does not depend on color alone.

The login window identifies ChurchManager, the local congregation, the installed version, and the open-source license. Confirm the congregation name before signing in, especially when working with a test or support installation.

The title bar clearly identifies a test database. Work entered in TEST MODE is not production congregation data.

Moving around

ChurchManager opens to a compact daily-work dashboard. The congregation's own logo and name identify the open church. Select a blue dashboard item for common weekly work, or use the application menus for setup, resource maintenance, design, reports, and other less-frequent work. Close a task window to return to the dashboard. Lists generally support double-clicking a row to open or edit the selected item. Buttons that are unavailable are disabled until the required selection is made.

Saving work

Use the screen's Save, Update, or Save Service control before closing. If a screen reports unsaved changes, choose whether to save or discard them. Red rows or red text identify information that still needs attention.

2. The main menu

The dashboard intentionally shows routine work rather than every ChurchManager function. The menu bar contains the complete authorized command set, grouped as **File**, **Church**, **Worship**, **People**, **Projects**, **Giving**, **Accounting**, **Reports**, **Tools**, and **Help**. Menu items appear or become available according to the signed-in user's permissions.

The church logo displayed on the dashboard comes from **Church > Church Information**. That screen also maintains the congregation name shown beside the logo. **Church** also contains the congregational Journal, Documents, Assets, Asset Locations, Maintenance Due, and Asset Reports. **People** is reserved for people, families, attendance, Groups, Pastoral Care, and Events.

Authorized designers can use **Tools > Designers** to open the Report Designer, Screen Designer, or Menu Designer. The protected starter remains available for recovery, and a saved menu customization is used the next time ChurchManager starts.

Service Planning

- **Worship Services** creates and completes a service plan and its weekly

Order of Service.

- **Weekly Bulletin Order** reviews the outline prepared for a particular

service.

- **Service Participants** assigns people to the positions required for a

service.

- **Notify Participants** prepares participant messages.
- **Weekly Prayers** and **Weekly Announcements** show material scheduled for

the selected week.

- **Prepare Bulletin Order** produces an outline suitable for copying into a

bulletin document.

Worship Resources

This group maintains sermons, local lectionaries, bulletin-order templates, prayers, announcements, hymnals, hymns, participants, positions, scheduling patterns, and preparation checklists. Installed package records are protected; make congregation-owned records or customized templates when changes are needed.

People and Congregation

This group contains people, families, attendance, Groups, Pastoral Care, and Events. Congregation-wide information, documents, journal records, and assets are under **Church**.

Church records, documents, and journal

Use **Church > Church Information** to maintain the congregation's name, address, contact information, report logo, primary hymnal, and default lectionary. Use **Church > Documents** to catalog an existing file. The catalog stores its title, date, type, description, and file location; it does not copy the file into the database. Moving or renaming a cataloged file can therefore break its Open action. The project `Documents` folder contains a fictional sample for ChurchDBTest.

Use **Church > Journal** for dated, non-financial congregational history such as council actions, significant ministry decisions, or property milestones. Do not use this general journal for accounting transactions, restricted pastoral notes, donor details, passwords, or other confidential narrative.

Authorized administrators use **Custom Profile Fields** under ChurchManager Settings to define bounded additional fields and controlled tags for People or Families. When creating a field, explicitly choose whether it may be used by approved search, report, or export surfaces. Create a field as a Draft, add choices when it is a single- or multiple-choice field, and then activate it. Retire fields and tags instead of deleting them so prior information remains understandable. Open a saved Person or Family and choose **Additional Information...** to enter the values. Standard and restricted fields follow separate permissions; custom fields must not be used for passwords, payment data, full worship content, or confidential pastoral narratives.

Double-click a field in **Custom Profile Fields**, or select it and choose **Open Field...**, to see its complete definition. A Draft may be edited freely. After activation, its stable structure is protected, but its label, help text, section, order, required setting, and approved search/report/export policies may still be adjusted. Retired definitions open read-only. A field does not appear in Custom Profile Search until it is Active and Searchable, and it does not appear in the custom-profile report until it is Active and approved for reports.

Use **Export Values...** for a separate custom-profile CSV. It includes only Active fields marked for approved export and writes a companion metadata file beside the CSV. Restricted fields are excluded unless an authorized user checks the separate Restricted option and confirms the warning. Use **Import Values...** to preview a compatible stable-key CSV and update existing People or Families. All rows must show **Ready** before import. Import does not create People, Families, field definitions, or choices; add those through their normal screens first. Keep the CSV and its metadata file together when transferring data.

Custom Profile Search under People and Congregation lists only active fields that were marked searchable and that the signed-in user may view. Choose the profile type, field, comparison, and value. Ranges and multiple-choice searches use comma-separated values; dates use `YYYY-MM-DD`. Double-click a result to open its Additional Information screen. Search results are bounded and never reveal restricted field metadata to an unauthorized user.

Run **Membership - Custom Profile Listing** from Reports to review fields that an administrator explicitly marked **Allow in approved reports**. The report lists Person and Family values together and identifies retired definitions as historical. Standard users never receive restricted custom values; those values appear only when the signed-in user also has the restricted custom-field permission. Custom fields remain excluded from ordinary directories and mailing labels unless a future purpose-built directory surface explicitly approves them.

Groups maintains committees, classes, studies, music groups, fellowship groups, and ministry teams separately from worship-service participant roles. Open a Group to review its current roster, add a dated membership term, end a membership without deleting its history, or assign a dated Group role. A Person, Group, and role must belong to the same congregation. Overlapping membership terms and duplicate overlapping role assignments are rejected. Restricted Groups appear only to users with the dedicated restricted-Group permission. Select **Show ended memberships** to review former members, their effective end dates, and their preserved historical terms. Authorized administrators may add congregation-owned **Group Types** and **Group Roles** from the Groups workspace. Retire an entry that should no longer be offered; retirement preserves its use on historical records.

Choose **Meetings** inside a Group to schedule an individual meeting and review its meeting history. Open a meeting to record Present, Absent, Excused, or Unknown for the roster effective on that date. Double-clicking a person cycles the status. An existing same-congregation Person may be added as a meeting guest without becoming a Group member. The optional total head count can include unidentified visitors without creating artificial Person records. Group meeting attendance remains separate from worship attendance. For routine entry, select **Group Attendance** directly from **People and Congregation**, choose the Group and meeting, and open the attendance screen. From a Group's meeting history, **Cancel Meeting** preserves a cancelled occurrence. **Reschedule** creates a new replacement occurrence and marks the original as Rescheduled, preserving the historical relationship.

The Reports screen includes **Groups - Current Roster**, **Groups - Person Participation History**, and **Groups - Meeting Attendance**. Select the Group or Person requested and, for meeting attendance, the reporting dates. Restricted Groups appear only for users who have permission to view them.

Volunteer availability and responses

Open **Participants**, select a worship participant, and choose **Availability...** to record dates when the person cannot serve. Select **All roles** for a general absence or a particular worship role for a limited exception. Keep the reason brief; pastoral and medical details do not belong in the scheduling record.

The **Service Participants** screen shows each response, the last date the person served in that role, and an Availability warning. A conflict never removes an assignment automatically. Edit the assignment or the unavailable period after speaking with the participant. A declined response leaves the required position open.

Notify Participants can prepare a service request, reminder, or general information message. Sending remains review-first and is disabled in TEST MODE. ChurchManager does not maintain a separate general calendar. **Events** under **People and Congregation** is a compact list for congregation dates that are not already Worship Services or Group Meetings. Each event stores only a public-safe title, date and optional time, location, status, and an external calendar eligibility choice. Enter recurrence naturally, such as **Every Tuesday and Thursday**, **First Tuesday of every month**, **Last Tuesday of the month**, **First Tuesday in October**, or **Once on October 1, 2026**. ChurchManager stores a standardized rule so later calendar exports are dependable. Reminders, invitations, and personal calendar notes remain in the external calendar.

Data Management provides a guarded duplicate review. Matching names, contact information, or mailing addresses are possible duplicates, not an automatic merge. Select a pair and choose **Not Duplicates** to record that both records are valid, or **Review Later** to remove the pair from the active queue. These decisions do not delete, merge, or alter either membership record. Select **Include matches marked Review Later** whenever those deferred pairs should be reconsidered.

Select **Review Merge Impact** to see how many attendance, contact, family, giving, user, participant, group, pastoral-care, and other linked records belong to each side. This preflight is generated from the current database relationships and makes no changes.

Select **Merge Records** only after reviewing that impact. Choose which record to keep, enter the reason, and confirm the operation. ChurchManager moves all linked history and removes the duplicate in one transaction. If the records own conflicting unique history, the whole merge is rolled back and neither record is changed. The merge reason and

record identities remain in protected history.

The beta test dataset includes two fictional records named **Pat Duplicate** so this review can be exercised without weakening the normal import protections.

Create Portable Archive produces a ZIP containing privacy-safe People and Families CSV files and a versioned checksum manifest. ChurchManager verifies the archive before reporting success. This is not a database backup: unlisted contact information, passwords, giving, accounting, audit internals, and pastoral-care information are excluded. instructions. Review the underlying records before making any correction.

Select **Preview Membership CSV** to inspect a People or Families CSV file. The first row must contain column names. Review every suggested mapping, map the required fields marked with an asterisk, and then select **Preview Mapped Rows**. Preview does not create or update records. Rows marked **Ready** may be imported; duplicate or invalid rows appear in red as **Excluded** and remain unchanged. **Import Reviewed Rows** creates only the Ready records in one transaction; any failure rolls back the whole import. It never merges or replaces existing records. ChurchManager records the church, user, file name and checksum, counts, and time, but does not retain the source rows. Safe sample files are available in `TestData` for both People and Families.

Select **Export Membership CSV** to create an authorized People or Families directory extract. Choose the church and destination file, then confirm the export. ChurchManager always excludes unlisted addresses, email addresses, and telephone numbers. The export contains no passwords, giving identity, accounting detail, pastoral records, or internal audit content. Export history stores attribution, counts, file name, and checksum rather than a copy of the exported rows.

Member Giving

This confidential group contains contributors and envelopes, approved giving purposes, contribution batches, and protected Giving reports. Its separate placement does not replace permission checks; users see and invoke only the operations their Giving roles permit.

Reports and Design

Use **Reports** to run approved reports. Authorized users may use **Report Designer** and **Screen Designer** to create congregation-specific layouts. Starter layouts remain available for recovery.

ChurchManager Settings

Authorized administrators maintain configuration, choices, users, email, catalog packages, backups, and support diagnostics here.

3. Church records

Church information

Enter the congregation's name, address, contact information, report logo, primary hymnal, and default lectionary. The selected hymnal and lectionary guide the choices offered in worship planning.

4. People and congregation records

People

Create one person record for each member or other person the congregation needs to track. A person may have a photograph and may be linked to a family. Opening **People** first displays **Select Person**. Type any part of a name to narrow the drop-down list, choose the person, and select **Open**. The ordinary Person edit screen opens at that person; its First, Previous, Next, and Last buttons still move through the complete People list. Select **New Person...** when the person has not been entered yet. Telephone numbers are stored as digits and formatted for display. Respect every unlisted-contact setting; unlisted contact information is excluded from public directory output.

Families

Family records group people for directories and household communication. A family may have its own photograph and address information. Confirm family membership before generating a directory. Opening **Families** first displays **Select Family**. Type any part of the family name to narrow the drop-down list, choose the family, and select **Open**. The ordinary Family edit screen opens at that family and retains navigation through every Family record. Select **New Family...** to start a new record.

Users are separate from people

A ChurchManager user may optionally be linked to a person record, but the two records serve different purposes. Not every member needs a user account, and a user does not have to be a congregation member.

Contributors and envelopes

For a contributor linked to a person or family, **Refresh from Directory...** shows each stored contact field beside the current directory value. Nothing is changed until the preview is confirmed. **Merge Duplicate...** keeps the currently selected contributor, moves the duplicate's Giving, envelope, and statement history, and deactivates the duplicate. ChurchManager blocks a merge when overlapping envelope or statement history must be resolved first, and it requires a permanent audit reason.

A giving contributor may be linked to one person, linked to one family, or maintained as an outside contributor. Statement identity and contact fields do not silently synchronize with the membership directory.

Numeric envelope numbers are normalized, so `001`, `01`, and `1` are the same number. Each assignment has a starting date and may have an ending date. ChurchManager prevents the same number from being assigned to different contributors during overlapping dates. Double-click an envelope-history row to edit it.

Approved giving purposes

Before entering contribution batches, a giving administrator records each congregation-approved purpose, its approval date and authority, effective dates, statement treatment, and accounting organization, fund, and revenue account. The required control-and-discretion confirmation documents that the congregation—not an individual donor—controls use of the gift.

Contribution batches

Open **Contribution Batches** to begin a confidential draft for a Sunday offering, special collection, or other deposit. Enter the batch date, description, accounting organization, and—when known—the expected control total. Open the batch and add each contribution.

For donated property, choose **Non Cash** as the method. Describe the property and then assign its approved giving purpose with a zero-dollar allocation. You may record an optional **Donor-provided estimate (unverified)** for internal reference. ChurchManager does not verify that estimate, use it in accounting, or print it as the congregation's valuation

on a contribution statement. A batch containing only non-cash gifts completes inside Giving after review and does not create a zero-dollar accounting transaction. Mixed batches send only their monetary amounts to accounting.

Choose **Import CSV** to map the columns in an electronic-giving or spreadsheet export. The preview reads the file without changing the database and marks unknown envelopes, contributors, purposes, conflicting identities, and possible duplicates in red. Import is not available until every row is resolved. After all rows are Ready, select the accounting organization, receiving bank account, deposit date, and batch description, then choose **Import Ready Rows to Draft Batch**. ChurchManager creates a new Draft batch; it does not post the gifts. The exact source CSV is retained in protected ChurchManager storage with its file hash and mapping, and the same file cannot be imported twice. The development test dataset includes `GivingImport.Valid.Sample.csv` and `GivingImport.Issues.Sample.csv` in the `TestData` folder for exercising both successful and flagged previews. Resetting the Giving test dataset also removes test import-evidence rows and their protected test copies after the replacement dataset commits successfully.

A Draft cannot be marked Ready unless its deposit date belongs to exactly one open fiscal period for its accounting organization. If an unsent Ready batch needs correction, select it in Contribution Batches and choose **Return Ready to Draft**. Use **Edit Batch Details** to correct its deposit date; the screen shows the accounting organization's currently open fiscal-period range. Batches already sent to Accounting cannot be returned this way.

Choose a contributor directly or enter an envelope number and leave the contributor at **Anonymous / resolve from envelope**. ChurchManager resolves the envelope assignment that was effective on the gift's received date. A gift may be divided among several approved purposes, but the allocations must equal the gift amount exactly. The batch header refreshes its entered total and any remaining difference after every saved gift.

Users with **Review contribution batches** permission can select **Review / Mark Ready**. ChurchManager first lists anything that still needs attention, including an unresolved envelope, control-total difference, incomplete split, expired purpose or accounting destination, donor-direction review, or duplicate check/reference value. A monetary or mixed batch changes to **Ready** only when every check passes. A non-cash-only batch changes directly to **Posted** because it has no bank deposit or accounting handoff.

While a batch remains Draft, double-click a contribution—or select **Edit Contribution**—to correct its contributor, envelope, amount, method, statement treatment, note, or purpose allocations. **Delete Contribution** requires confirmation. Both operations immediately recalculate the batch total and add a privacy-safe audit event. Ready and posted gifts cannot be edited or deleted.

To correct a posted batch, select it in **Contribution Batches** and choose **Correct Posted Batch**. Enter an open-period correction date and a required reason. ChurchManager creates a Ready accounting reversal and an editable Draft copy of the original gifts. Approve and post the reversal through normal Accounting Posting before reviewing and sending the replacement batch. The original batch remains in the audit history with Void status. Once a Ready batch has created its summarized accounting transaction, the batch list displays **Sent to Accounting** until that transaction is posted.

For a returned check, select its Posted batch and choose **Returned Check...**. Select the check, enter the bank return date and an audit reason, and confirm the correction. ChurchManager creates the full summarized accounting reversal and a Draft replacement batch that omits only the returned check. Post the reversal before reviewing and sending the replacement batch. The original gift remains unchanged in the protected audit history, and donor identity never enters the accounting reversal.

Giving reports

Open **Giving Reports** for operational review. **Batch Control Summary** shows batch dates, statuses, controls, entered totals, differences, and accounting transaction links without displaying donor identity. Users with confidential history permission also receive **Contributor History**, which shows one contributor's Ready and Posted allocations for the selected dates. Draft gifts are deliberately excluded from contributor history. The **Refresh** buttons update the on-screen review and display the completion time beneath the grid; they do not create a PDF. **Preview PDF** on the Batch Control Summary creates the protected donor-free `CMGV01` report for the selected dates. Contributor statements are available only to users with the statement-generation permission.

The **Operational Reports** tab provides protected printable batch detail, contributor history, statement exceptions, and envelope exceptions. It also provides donor-free **Giving by Fund and Period** and **Accounting Posting Reconciliation** reports. Select the dates, choose the report, select a contributor only when printable Contributor History requires one, and choose **Preview Selected Report**. On **Contribution Statements**, select either **Quarterly**, **Calendar Year**, or **Custom Date Range**, then select one contributor or **All eligible contributors** and choose **Preview Statement(s)**. The preview includes only Posted gifts and only allocations marked statement eligible. Previewing does not record that a statement was issued or delivered. Choose **Issue and Record Statement(s)** only when the PDF is being treated as an official statement. ChurchManager records its covered period, generation time, revision, filename, and SHA-256 identifier. This does not claim the statement was printed, mailed, emailed, or received. **Statement Issuance History** identifies prior issues and reissues.

Statements list non-cash gifts by their stored description with a blank Amount cell. They are not included in **Eligible monetary contributions**. Any donor-provided estimate remains internal, unverified information and is not printed as the congregation's valuation.

Users with confidential Giving-report permission also receive **Memorial / Honor Gifts**. Select the covered dates and choose **Preview Memorial / Honor List** to create a protected acknowledgment-work PDF containing Posted gifts only. The donor name appears only when donor disclosure was explicitly authorized; otherwise it says **Not disclosed**. The amount appears only when amount disclosure was separately authorized. These two permissions are never inferred from one another.

Use **Acknowledgment / Tribute...** while entering a contribution to record a special donor instruction. Select **Needs review** until the congregation has decided how it will respond. A completed disposition requires a resolution note; ChurchManager records the resolving user and time automatically. **Returned to donor** retains the review record but excludes the amount from the deposit, ledger handoff, and contribution statement. **Accepted under congregation control** documents that the congregation retains control and discretion over an approved purpose. ChurchManager documents the action; it does not decide tax deductibility. Use **Giving Reports > Directed Gift Review** for the confidential review and disposition list.

5. Worship planning

Create a worship service

1. Open **Worship Services** and create a new service.
2. Enter the service date, time, location, and congregation.
3. Select an Order of Service template.
4. Select a Proper when one applies. The Proper supplies the printable

liturgical title, color, reading citations, and hymn suggestions.

5. Review the service outline on the left and the service details on the right.

6. Fill every required hymn or reading line and resolve red warnings.
7. Assign participants and review the Preparation Checklist.
8. Save the service.

Creating a worship service also creates its attendance event. The saved weekly Order of Service is a service snapshot; later changes to the source template do not rewrite the saved service.

Order of Service templates

Templates store outline metadata only. They do not contain complete liturgical texts, prayers, psalms, lyrics, music, or publisher artwork. Create an editable custom template from a starter or create one from scratch. Required participant positions may be attached to a template and carried into a new service.

Hymns

Select a hymn line before using **Select Hymn**. The hymn picker searches and sorts the congregation's installed hymnal entries. A selected hymn displays its title as the weekly value and its hymnal number as the reference. Select stanzas when needed. Duplicate hymn selections are always flagged, including duplicates chosen manually.

For Lutheran Service Book references, pages in the service section use the form `LSB p. 151`; printed hymns use the form `LSB 331`. Psalms are citations, not LSB page references.

Readings, colors, and titles

ChurchManager stores biblical citations, not Scripture text. A service planner may override a reading in the weekly outline. The printable liturgical title comes from the Proper. A service-specific color override updates the color block on the planning screen and planning report.

Preparation checklist

The checklist is a planning reminder, not a hard closing system. Items may be Done, Not Done, or Not Needed. One-time tasks may be added to a service. The summary reports checklist progress, required participant coverage, and hymn completion. Marking the whole checklist complete records the planner's judgment even when an exception is intentional.

6. Attendance

Open **Attendance** and choose an event. Worship services normally create their attendance events automatically. Members appear first, followed by visitors. Visitors may be counted without creating person records. Record communion only when it was offered and the information is appropriate to maintain.

Available reports include event listings, weekly attendance, year-to-date totals, individual history, member follow-up, and a pastor's comparison report. The follow-up report can flag members after a chosen number of consecutive missed weeks.

7. Prayers, announcements, and participant notices

Prayers and announcements use categories maintained in Choices. Their natural language schedules may describe patterns such as `Every Sunday`, `First and Third Sunday of the month`, or an approved fixed annual date. Scheduling is week-based so material may apply to Sunday, Wednesday, or another service in the same ministry week. Unsupported or ambiguous expressions are rejected.

Use the weekly preview before preparing bulletin material. Participant notices use the congregation's configured email service. TEST MODE never sends external email.

8. Pastoral Care

Pastoral Care is a protected ministry work list for follow-ups, completed care actions, and future reminders. It is not a counseling transcript, medical record, safeguarding case file, or place to record everything a caregiver knows.

Follow-ups and actions

Open **Pastoral Care** from the main menu. **Assigned to Me** shows your open work; authorized users may select **All Open**. Create a follow-up with the correct church, person or family when applicable, category, assignee, priority, opened date, and optional due date. Keep the safe summary brief and minimum-necessary.

Double-click a follow-up to review its safe history, record a completed action, set the next follow-up, assign it, or change its status. Regular shut-in and homebound visits may use the natural-language scheduling pattern provided by the screen.

Attendance and Prayer Requests can deliberately create a Pastoral Care follow-up. ChurchManager does not copy an attendance-event note or the wording of a prayer request into the follow-up. Review the new record and add only the safe operational detail that is actually needed.

Pastoral Care reports and confidentiality

Pastoral Care - Work List contains authorized operational fields. **Pastoral Care - Activity Summary** contains aggregate counts. Neither report includes restricted notes or confidential narrative. Report access is protected by Pastoral Care permissions.

Authorized users may select **Restricted Notes...** from a follow-up history. The list shows dates and updater information only; note text stays closed until one note is explicitly opened. Creating or changing a note also requires the restricted-note edit permission and verified recovery protection. Use the minimum necessary wording. Restricted notes never appear in reports, exports, diagnostics, or search. Do not place confidential narrative in an ordinary summary, action, report, document, prayer request, or other unprotected field.

ChurchManager is a reminder and recordkeeping aid, not an emergency-response or mandated-reporting system. Follow the congregation's safeguarding procedures and applicable law whenever immediate action or a report to civil authorities may be required.

9. Reports and layout customization

Select a report, supply its enabled parameters, and choose **Run Report**, or double-click the selected report row. ChurchManager creates a PDF using a protected report dataset. A customized layout is shown in blue; when no customization exists, ChurchManager uses the starter layout.

Authorized users may open the Report Designer, create a customization from a starter, move and resize controls, preview the PDF, validate the definition, and restore the starter. Report definitions control presentation only; they do not bypass report permissions or expose unapproved database fields.

10. Fund accounting

Initial setup

Complete Accounting Setup, the chart of accounts, funds and restrictions, functional classifications, fiscal years and periods, bank accounts, and payees before entering live transactions.

Daily work

1. Create a balanced draft in **Transaction Entry**.
2. Review it and mark it ready.
3. Approve it under the congregation's approval policy.
4. Post it. Posting makes the accounting entry permanent.
5. Use a reversing transaction to correct a posted entry.

Small congregations may enable the audited solo-approval policy. When used, the override and its reason remain in the audit history.

Bank work and reconciliation

Bank File Import previews and stages a bank CSV; it does not post transactions. Match imported lines carefully, complete the reconciliation, and review the reconciliation report before closing the period.

Budgets and period end

Budgets may use general accounts alone or include detailed line items. Review Budget to Actual and the Close Checklist before period or year-end processing. Year-End Close is controlled and auditable; make a verified backup first.

11. Users, email, backup, and recovery

Calendar Integration

Use **Calendar Integration** under ChurchManager Settings to combine eligible Church Events, Worship Services, and standard Group Meetings for a selected date range. Select **Preview Calendar** before exporting. Only sources the signed-in user may view are available. Select **Export .ics** to create a portable calendar file that can be imported by Google Calendar, Outlook, Apple Calendar, and other calendar applications.

Export does not change ChurchManager or the external calendar. Repeating the export creates another snapshot.

An administrator may optionally connect a production installation to Google Calendar. Place the Google desktop OAuth client file at `%LOCALAPPDATA%\ChurchManager\OAuth\client_secret.json`, enter `primary` (or a specific Google Calendar identifier), select **Connect to Google**, preview the range, and then select **Publish Preview**. ChurchManager shows how many events will be created, updated, cancelled, or left unchanged before final confirmation. ChurchManager remains the source of truth; Google edits do not return to ChurchManager and may be replaced by a later publish.

The Google token is kept in Windows Credential Manager and is not included in the ChurchManager database or backup. Google publishing is disabled in TEST MODE. Automatic and two-way synchronization are not supported.

Asset Management

Open **Assets** to maintain a simple congregational register of equipment, furnishings, instruments, technology, vehicles, and other property. Each asset has a permanent congregation-assigned number, name, category, location, condition, status, and optional acquisition, value, warranty, maintenance, and replacement-review information. Reference value is planning information; Asset Management does not calculate depreciation or replace the accounting ledger.

Use **Locations** before entering assets so rooms, buildings, and storage areas are named consistently. Double-click an asset to review or edit it and to add dated maintenance, movement, repair, inspection, retirement, or other activity. Activity history is retained rather than overwritten. Retired, lost, and disposed assets require a date and remain in history.

Maintenance Due lists active assets whose maintenance or replacement-review date is approaching. The Asset Register, Maintenance Due, and Asset Activity History reports are available under Reports.

CSV import is a reviewed, all-or-nothing operation. Create locations first, select **Import CSV**, map an approved file, and review every row. Duplicate asset numbers, unknown locations, invalid dates, or other errors must be fixed before import. Repeated serial numbers are shown as warnings. Dates use `YYYY-MM-DD`. CSV export contains the current register fields but does not include activity history, documents, or protected information.

Projects and Scheduling

Open **Projects and Scheduling** for bounded congregational work such as an annual meeting, fellowship event, building improvement, or stewardship effort. Each project has a stable project number, one accountable owner, status, priority, optional dates, a stated purpose, and an ordered list of concrete steps. A Group may be selected when responsibility is shared.

Save a new project as **Active** before adding steps. Double-click a step to edit it. Use **Move Up** and **Move Down** to arrange the work, **Dependencies** to identify a step that must be completed first, and **Documents** to link an existing ChurchManager document without copying its file. A blocked step must include a short reason. Red rows identify blocked or overdue work, but the written status remains authoritative.

The Due Work tab shows approaching and overdue steps. Calendar publication is optional for both project target dates and step due dates; use Calendar Integration to preview and export eligible items. The Projects reports provide an active summary, due and overdue work, a project plan, and completed history. Project notes are ordinary operational notes and must not contain pastoral, donor, personnel, medical, or other confidential narratives.

Users and roles

Administrators create individual accounts and assign only the permissions each user needs. In **User Administration**, set the congregation's minimum password length between 8 and 128 characters. The setting applies to newly entered and generated passwords for new accounts, administrative resets, and user password changes; it does not invalidate an existing password until that password is changed.

When creating a user or resetting a password, select **Generate** to create a secure temporary password using the active minimum length. Copy it while the dialog remains open and communicate it separately. The temporary password is not recoverable afterward and is never included in welcome email. The user must change it at the next login.

A new account may be linked to a person and may receive a first-login notice after outgoing email has been configured. Disable accounts that should no longer sign in instead of reusing them. Inactive users remain visible with an **Active** value of **No** and a different row color.

Email

Configure the congregation's SMTP provider under **Email Settings** and test the connection. Credentials are protected locally and are not written into reports, logs, or database backups. TEST MODE suppresses delivery.

Backup

Use **Database Backup** regularly and before migrations, restore operations, year-end close, or major catalog changes. The default backup folder may be changed. An optional automatic backup can run when ChurchManager exits. Keep the permanent backup folder outside MariaDB's data folder; preferably use a separate physical device or independently protected network location so one disk failure does not destroy both the database and its backups.

Pastoral Care recovery protection

Before restricted pastoral notes can ever be enabled, a Master Administrator must configure a separate Pastoral Care recovery password in **Database Backup**. ChurchManager does not store that password and cannot recover it.

An authorized Master Administrator may use **Rotate Encryption Key** from that same protected section. Rotation requires the recovery password and creates separate, clearly labeled before-and-after backups. Do not interrupt ChurchManager or MariaDB while it is running. Keep both backups and their matching sidecars according to the congregation's protected retention policy.

A complete backup of encrypted pastoral notes consists of two matched files: the SQL backup, which contains ciphertext only, and its protected pastoral recovery sidecar. Preserve both files together in protected storage. The SQL file alone cannot make restricted notes readable on a replacement computer. Restore must reject a missing, altered, mismatched, or incorrectly protected sidecar without silently clearing a note.

Restore

Restore replaces the active database with the selected backup. Read every warning, verify the database name shown, and allow the operation to finish. ChurchManager must restart after a successful restore because its previous database connections were closed.

12. Getting help

Select **Help - User Guide** on the main menu to open this document. If an unexpected error occurs, note what you were doing and open **Support and Diagnostics**. Create the privacy-safe support package and give that package to the person supporting ChurchManager. Do not send database passwords.

The application version appears in the ChurchManager title bar. Include that version when requesting help.

ChurchManager is open-source congregation software. This guide describes the 0.3.0-beta.5 beta line and will be revised as beta testing identifies additional instructions or screenshots that are needed.